

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Mystery drama

DIRECTOR

Orson Welles

WRITERS

Orson Welles,
Herman J. Mankiewicz

STARS

Orson Welles, Joseph
Cotten, Dorothy
Comingore

BEFORE

1938 Welles directs a radio adaptation of H. G. Wells's *War of the Worlds*, about an invasion from Mars. Its news-bulletin style is said to have caused some listeners to believe that it was real.

AFTER

1958 Welles's noir thriller *Touch of Evil* tells a story of corruption in a Mexican border town.

1962 Welles makes a visually stunning adaptation of Franz Kafka's novel *The Trial*.

I don't think any word can explain a man's life," says Charles Foster Kane, the towering press-baron protagonist of *Citizen Kane*. And yet the genius of this movie—cowritten, starring, and directed by Orson Welles at the age of just 25—is that it does just that: takes a single word that captures the origin and essence of the mercurial Kane, and teases the audience with it for nearly two hours, before offering an enigmatic clue to its meaning.

Shot in secrecy to preempt legal attempts to block production, and ambiguously billed as a love story, Welles braced himself for trouble upon its release. Kane's character was not only based on a living person, but one who was extremely powerful.

Citizen Kane is a murder mystery without a murder, even though it famously opens with Kane, in old age, as a dying man. Starting his movie at the end is just the first of Welles's many innovative

Your faithful bystander reports that he has just seen a picture which he thinks must be the best picture he ever saw.

John O'Hara
Newsweek, 1941

temporal devices. The narrative then switches to a newsreel clip that recalls the life and deeds of the great Kane. It shows the building of his stately home, Xanadu, a sprawling mansion that he fills with art ("Enough for ten museums—the loot of the world"). It shows Kane's influence spreading across the US and then across the world, as he stands on a balcony next to Adolf

“Old age. It's the only disease...that you don't look forward to being cured of.”

Bernstein / Citizen Kane

Orson Welles Director



Welles's life mirrors that of Charles Foster Kane, in that he was taken in by a family friend, having lost both parents at 15. In 1934, he began working on radio plays and in 1937 founded the Mercury Theater—two things that would bring him great notoriety in 1938 when the company performed *War of the Worlds* as a live news broadcast. Welles was approached by RKO Studios in Hollywood, where he was given unheard of privileges for a new director,

including the final cut for *Citizen Kane*. His next movie *The Magnificent Ambersons*, was butchered by RKO, the first of many creative quarrels that would plague his career. He died at 70 in 1985.

Key movies

1941 *Citizen Kane*
1942 *The Magnificent Ambersons*
1958 *Touch of Evil*
1962 *The Trial*